

The Crucible – Act Two

Arthur Miller

Responding Critically

Answer the following items completely.

1. What evidence can be found that Abigail and her party of accusers, including Mary Warren, have undergone a change in status since the beginning of the play? Use examples to support your answer.
2. What is the central conflict that John Proctor faces?
3. Does the Reverend Hale still believe as firmly in the truth of the accusations, or is he beginning to have some doubts? Cite examples to support your answer.
4. What commandment does Proctor fail to recollect? Why is this significant?
5. Someone once said that the best defense is a good offense. Do you think that John Proctor may be hinting at this when he asks why the accusers are always innocent now? Explain your answer.
6. Identify a voice of reason in Act Two. Argue your answer with careful evidence.
7. At the end of Act Two, what is learned about Mary Warren's motives?
8. The theme of human cruelty versus righteousness is particularly important in this act. Go through Act Two and select three quotes that represent this theme. Critically explore these quotes in a five-paragraph essay, discussing what they reveal about the characters and plot of *The Crucible*.

Ongoing Activity (I)

The reader learns a considerable amount about the characters of *The Crucible* in Act Two. Reverend Hale, for instance, is revealed to be particularly complex. Beginning with Act Two and for the remainder of the play, trace Hale's opinions about

- a. his beliefs about the court system
- b. witchcraft, and his ability to identify witches
- c. his belief about the role of the church in all aspects of life